

RIDING HIGH Congress leader Bhupinder Singh Hooda campaigning in Sonipat, Sept. 20

port base to keep the Congress at bay at least in Bagar. This region also borders south Punjab, a strong base of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which is fighting independently and has made the contest multi-cornered. The BJP, on its part, is working on the 'forward-backward' formula to take on the Congress's Jat-Dalit coalition. Incidentally, Bagar is also Selja's area of influence.

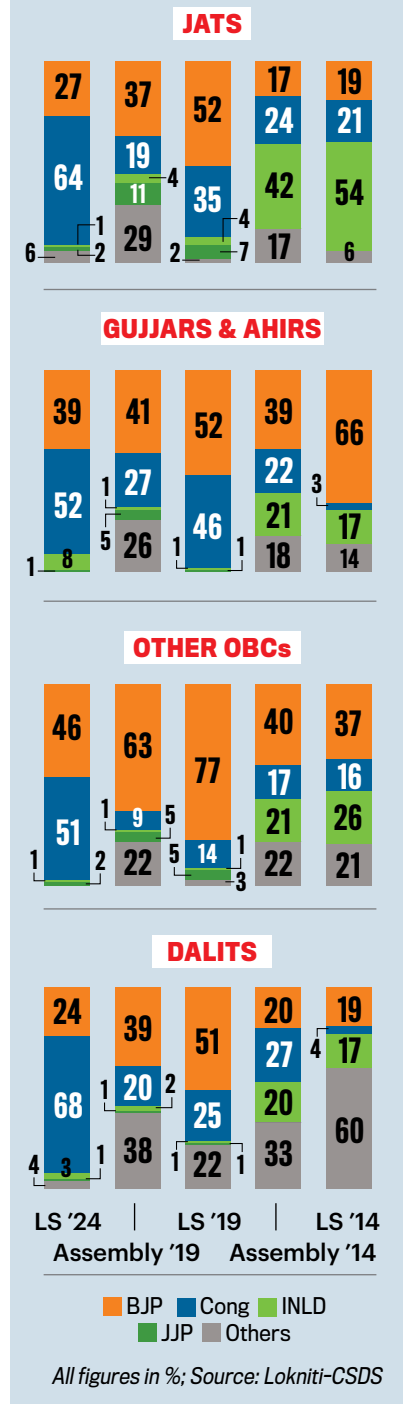
THE BJP'S FORWARD-BACKWARD FORMULA

The BJP is trying to placate the agrarian communities by committing to procure all 24 crops on minimum support price (MSP). This also somewhat balances out the Congress's promise to provide a legal guarantee on MSP. "We are already buying 14 crops on MSP (highest across India). We pay *bhavantar* (price difference) to vegetable farmers. If you look at the data, agriculture has grown 8.1 per cent in our regime," Saini told INDIA TODAY. Add to that promised freebies like a scooter for every college-going student in rural areas and separate welfare boards with adequate funding for 36 smaller backward communities, and there's a lot on offer. Such measures may not calm down the Jats but could help woo other OBC farmers in the GT Road (north Haryana) and Ahirwal-Mewat (south) belt of the state, both traditional bases for the BJP.

Just like Jats, even Gujjars, Ahirs and other OBC leaders had been feeling ignored during Khattar's rule. In Saini, the BJP gave the state its first non-Jat OBC chief minister in five decades, weeks before the general election this year. Now, it wants to secure a larger share of votes from this backward segment.

THE CASTE FACTOR

How the backward caste vote has shifted so far



All figures in %; Source: Lokniti-CSDS

The BJP has strategically allocated 22 seats to the OBCs, in comparison to the Congress's 20. A BJP insider claims that no "popular or mass leader has been ignored" this time. For instance, while Lok Sabha MP Krishan Pal Gurjar's son Devender Chaudhary could not be fielded, a top leader confides that at least five of his loyalists were nominated. Similarly, Union minister Rao Inderjit Singh's daughter Arti Singh Rao has made it to the list of candidates apart from nine loyalists. On the other hand, Khattar may have been able to secure candidature for his 12 supporters, but nine of his closest aides couldn't make the cut. Despite his camp's opposition, the BJP has also reposed faith in veteran leaders like former home minister Anil Vij (Ambala Cantt) and assembly speaker Gian Chand Gupta (Panchkula).

As for Jats, the BJP has fielded 16, far less than the Congress's 29, including Hooda. There are 37 seats where Jats account for over 25 per cent of the electorate. In the Lok Sabha election, the Congress managed to take the lead in 27 of these segments, while the remaining 10 went the BJP's way. With the community expected to vote overwhelmingly for the Congress (read, Hooda), the BJP has chosen to experiment with a mix of candidates from forward and backward castes. In rural Haryana, Jats and Brahmins are seen as traditional rivals. So while Jat candidates of the two parties will be engaged in a duel in 14 seats, the BJP has fielded 11 Brahmin candidates in Jat-dominated constituencies, hoping that the unwavering support of forward castes will see them through in these tough contests.

Ultimately, the election outcome will hinge on how these various caste and community equations play out on the ground, down to the micro level where Independents and rebel candidates will have localised spheres of influence. The results will have significant implications not just for Haryana or for the key contenders, but also for the larger political dynamics in the region. ■